

conjunction with his sister, Artemis (see p. 225). Can one ever forget Homer's terrifying picture of the god as he lays low the Greek forces at Troy with a plague in response to the appeal of his priest Chryses (*Iliad* 1. 43–52)?

Phoebus Apollo . . . came down from the peaks of Olympus, angered in his heart, wearing on his shoulders his bow and closed quiver. The arrows clashed on his shoulders as he moved in his rage, and he descended just like night. Then he sat down apart from the ships and shot one of his arrows; terrible was the clang made by his silver bow. First he attacked the mules and the swift hounds, but then he let go his piercing shafts against the men themselves and struck them down. The funeral pyres with their corpses burned thick and fast.

Yet this same god is the epitome of Greek classical restraint, championing the proverbial Greek maxims: "Know thyself" and "Nothing too much." He knows by experience the dangers of excess. From a sea of blood and guilt, Apollo brings enlightenment, atonement, and purification wherever he may be, but especially in his sanctuary at Delphi.

The origins of Apollo are obscure. He may have been one of the gods brought into Greece by the northern invaders of 2000 B.C.; if not, he was probably soon absorbed by them in the period 2000–1500. Some scholars imagine Apollo as originally the prototype of the Good Shepherd, with his many protective powers and skills, especially those of music and medicine.³⁰ As we have seen in Chapter 3, he becomes a sun-god and usurps the power of Hyperion and of Helius.

For many, Apollo appears to be the most characteristically Greek god in the whole pantheon—a gloriously conceived anthropomorphic figure, perhaps epitomized best of all in the splendid depiction of the west pediment of the great temple of Zeus at Olympia (see p. 269). Here Apollo stood with calm intelligent strength, his head turned to one side, his arm upraised against the raging turmoil of the battle between the Centaurs and Lapiths by which he is surrounded.

By stressing his disciplined control and intellectuality and ignoring his tumultuous extremes of passion, Apollo may be presented as the direct antithesis of the god Dionysus. In the persons of these two deities, the rational (Apollonian) and irrational (Dionysiac) forces in human psychology, philosophy, and religion are dramatically pitted against one another. Some scholars maintain that Apollo represents the true and essential nature of the Greek spirit, as reflected in the poetry of Homer, in contrast to the later, foreign intrusion of the mysticism of Dionysus. Whatever kernel of truth this view may hold, it must be realized that by the sixth and fifth centuries B.C., Dionysus had become an integral part of Greek civilization. By the classical period, he was as characteristically Greek as Apollo, and *both* deities actually reflect a basic duality inherent in the Greek conception of things. We have already detected in Chapter 3 this same dichotomy in the union of the mystical and mathematical that was mirrored in the amalgamation



Christus Apollo. Vault mosaic, third century A.D.; height of vault 72 in. Christ is shown with the attributes of the sun-god (Apollo or Helius), ascending into the vault of the sky on a chariot drawn by four white horses (two are missing from the damaged part). The rays emanating from his head form a cross. Across the background trails the ivy of Dionysus, another pagan symbol of immortality used in early Christian art. This vault mosaic is in a Christian tomb in the cemetery beneath the basilica of St. Peter's in the Vatican. (*Scala/Art Resource, NY*)

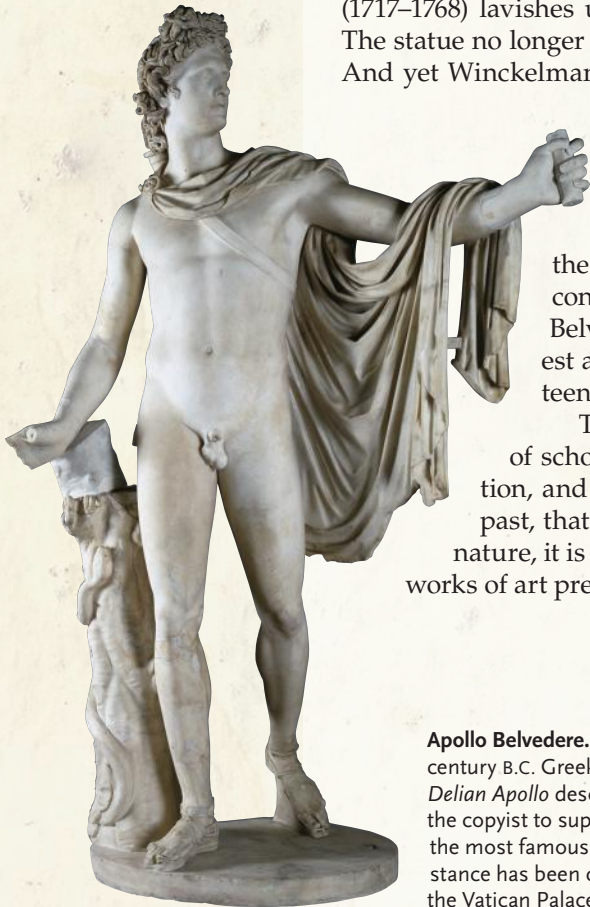
Images of Apollo

The statue of Apollo is the highest ideal of art among all the works of antiquity that have escaped its destruction. . . . This Apollo surpasses all other images of him as much as the Apollo of Homer surpasses those portrayed by later poets. His build is elevated above the human, and his stance bears witness to the fullness of his grandeur. An eternal springtime, like that of the blissful Elysian Fields, clothes the alluring virility of mature years with a pleasing youth and plays with soft tenderness upon the lofty structure of his limb. . . . In gazing upon this masterpiece of art, I forget all else, and I myself adopt an elevated stance, in order to be worthy of gazing upon it. My chest seems to expand with veneration and to leave like those I have seen swollen as if by the spirit of prophecy, and I feel myself transported to Delos and to the Lycian groves, places Apollo honored with his presence—for my figure seems to take on life and movement, like Pygmalion's beauty. How is it possible to paint and describe it!³¹

To many, the effusiveness that the art historian Johann Joachim Winckelmann (1717–1768) lavishes upon the Apollo Belvedere is difficult now to appreciate. The statue no longer holds its once august position in the Western canon of art. And yet Winckelmann's aesthetic taste left such an indelible mark on the centuries that followed and contributed so much to the enshrinement of this statue, at least in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries, as one of the highest expressions of Greek art, that it is a bit sobering to reflect that he wrote at a time when the remarkable statues that graced the Parthenon had not yet filtered more broadly into European consciousness. As a result of this early reception, the Apollo Belvedere has had a profound influence on some of the greatest artists and most iconic art since its discovery in the late fifteenth or early sixteenth century.

The Apollo Belvedere has proven to be both a battleground of scholarly debate as to its origin, history, and artistic appreciation, and a mirror reflecting the viewer's relationship to the Greek past, that is, what he or she wishes to see in it. Because of this dual nature, it is nearly impossible to see it afresh. A comparison of the two works of art presented here is instructive.

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Apollo Belvedere. Roman marble copy, possibly of the second century A.D., of a fourth-century B.C. Greek bronze; height 94½ in. Apollo strides ahead just as the *Homeric Hymn to Delian Apollo* describes. His left hand would have held his bow: the tree trunk was added by the copyist to support the weight of the marble on the right ankle and foot. This has been the most famous statue of Apollo since its discovery in Rome in or before 1509, and its stance has been copied in innumerable works of art. It takes its name from the courtyard in the Vatican Palace where it stands in its own niche. (Vatican Museum, Cortile del Belvedere)

The severe angularity, commanding stillness, and strength of the Apollo from the west pediment of the temple of Zeus at Olympia does indeed contrast with what some have called the “effeminate” softness and awkward movement of the Belvedere, whose head, glance, and upper torso are directed toward his left, while his stride carries him to the right. In general terms, the Belvedere seems to be an inversion of the Olympian Apollo; the figures are gazing and gesturing in opposite directions. If the Belvedere is a Roman copy of a fourth-century Greek original (and certainty eludes us), then perhaps it is a deliberate rejection of the classical ideals represented in the pedimental Apollo.

The Apollo at Olympia is the calm focal point within a narrative of violence (the assault upon the Lapith women by centaurs); the composition is thereby made coherent and gains in intensity by the contrast of the god with the other figures. The Belvedere is unmoored from any such context. Though some, like Winckelmann, have argued that he has just triumphed over the Python and taken possession of Delphi, this is far from certain. Without that strong narrative context, the Belvedere seems somehow detached, bestriding the world, indifferent to where he’s going.



Apollo. From the west pediment of the temple of Zeus at Olympia, ca. 460 B.C.; height of complete figure ca. 120 in. This is the central figure in the pediment (see p. 120). Son of Zeus, he imposes peace on the drunken brawl of the Lapiths and centaurs at the wedding of Pirithoüs (also the subject of the metopes on the south side of the Parthenon). The ancient traveler Pausanias thought that the figure was Pirithoüs, but no modern scholars accept his interpretation. (*Alinari/Art Resource, NY*)

of two cultures (the Nordic and the Mediterranean) in the Minoan and Mycenaean periods.

Just as Apollo may be made a foil for the mystical Dionysus, so he may be used as a meaningful contrast to the figure of the spiritual Christ. Each in his person and his life represents, physically and spiritually, different concepts of meaning and purpose in both this world and the next. Apollo and Christ do indeed afford a startling and revealing antithesis.

Here now is the brief *Homeric Hymn to Apollo* (21):

Phoebus, about you even the swan sings clearly as it wings its way and alights on the bank along the swirling river, Peneus; and about you the sweet-voiced minstrel with his lovely sounding lyre always sings both first and last. (1–4)

So hail to you, lord; I propitiate you with my song.

Additional Reading: Homeric Hymn to Pythian Apollo



Audio

THE *HOMERIC HYMN TO APOLLO* (3. 179–546: TO PYTHIAN APOLLO)

O lord, you hold Lycia and charming Maeonia and Miletus, desirable city on the sea; but you yourself rule mightily over Delos, washed by the waves. (179–180)

The renowned son of Leto, dressed in divine and fragrant garments, goes to rocky Pytho, as he plays upon his hollow lyre; at the touch of his golden pick, the lyre makes a lovely sound. From there, as swift as thought, he soars from earth to Olympus, to the house of Zeus and the company of the other gods. Immediately the immortals are obsessed with the lyre and song. The Muses, all together, harmonize with their charming voices and celebrate the endless gifts enjoyed by the gods and the sufferings inflicted by these immortals that human beings must bear, as they live foolish and helpless lives, unable to find a defense against old age and a cure for death. (181–193) 10

Also, the Graces with beautiful hair, and the cheerful Hours, and Harmonia, Hebe, and Aphrodite, daughter of Zeus, dance together, holding hands at the wrist; and with them sings a goddess who is not slight or homely but awesome to behold and wondrously beautiful, Artemis, who delights in her arrows, sister to Apollo. Among them too, Ares and the keen-eyed slayer of Argus join in the merriment, and Apollo continues to play his beautiful music on the lyre, as he steps high and stately. The radiance from his glittering feet and glistening robe envelop him in splendor. Both golden-haired Leto and wise Zeus watch their dear son playing his music among the immortal gods and rejoice in their mighty hearts. (194–206) 20

Shall I sing about you as a suitor in your love affairs? How you went to woo the daughter of Azan along with godlike Ischys, the son of Elatus famous for his horses, or with Phorbas, the son of Triops, or with Ereuthus or with Leucippus for the wife [to be] of Leucippus, you on foot and he from his chariot; indeed he was not a rival inferior to Triops.³² (207–213)

APOLLO SEEKS A SITE FOR HIS ORACLE

Or shall I sing about how at first you went over all the earth, seeking a location for your oracle for the human race, O far-shooting Apollo?³³ First, you came

down from Olympus to Pieria and went past sandy Lectus and Enienae and
 through the territory of the Perrhaebi. Soon you came to Iolcus and entered 30
 Ceneae in Euboea, famous for its ships, and you stood on the Lelantine plain;
 but it did not please your heart to build a temple amidst forest groves. From
 there you crossed the Euripus, far-shooting Apollo, and made your way along
 the holy green mountains, and quickly you went on from here to Mycalessus and
 grassy Teumessus and reached the forest-covered home of Thebe; for no one
 of mortals as yet lived in holy Thebes, nor were there yet at that time paths or
 roads running through the wheat-bearing plain of Thebes; but it was overgrown
 with trees. (214–228)

From there you went further, O far-shooting Apollo, and came to Onchestus,
 with its splendid grove of Poseidon. Here, while the newly broken colt, worn out 40
 with drawing the beautiful chariot, slows down to get its wind, the noble driver
 springs out of his seat to the ground and makes his own way. Without guid-
 ance, the horses for a time knock about the empty chariot; and, if they smash
 it in the forest grove, the horses are taken care of but the chariot is put at a tilt
 and left there. For in this way from the very first the holy rite was enacted. They
 pray to the god, lord of the shrine, who then keeps the chariot as his allotted
 portion.³⁴ From there you went further, far-shooting Apollo, and then you came
 upon the beautifully flowing river, Cephissus, which pours its sweet-running
 water from Lillaea; you crossed it, and from many-towered Ocalea you arrived at 50
 grassy Haliartus. Then you went to Telphusa; here was a propitious place that
 you found pleasing for making a forest grove and a temple. You stood very near
 her and spoke these words: “Telphusa, here I intend to build a very beautiful
 temple, an oracle for mortals. Here all those who live in the rich Peloponnesus,
 in Europe, and on the sea-girt islands will bring perfect hecatombs and consult
 the oracle. To them I shall deliver my answers and ordain infallible counsel in my
 wealthy temple.” (229–253)

Thus, Phoebus Apollo spoke and laid out the foundations, wide and very
 long overall. But Telphusa, upon seeing his actions, became deeply incensed
 and spoke: “Phoebus, lord and far-worker, I shall give you this warning to think 60
 about. Since you intend to build a very beautiful temple here, to be an oracle for
 mortals, who will always bring perfect hecatombs, I will speak out and you take
 my words to heart. The clatter of swift horses and the sounds of mules being wa-
 tered at my holy spring will always annoy you; here any person will prefer to look
 at the well-made chariots and the noisy swift-footed horses rather than at your
 great temple and the many treasures inside. But if you were to listen to me (you
 are better and stronger than I am and your might is the greatest), build in Crisa,
 beneath the slopes of Mt. Parnassus, where beautiful chariots will not clatter
 and no noise will be made by swift-footed horses around your well-built altar. So
 there hordes of renowned mortals will bring gifts to you as *le Paeon*,³⁵ and you
 will rejoice greatly in your heart to receive the beautiful sacrifices of the people 70
 living roundabout.” Thus, Telphusa spoke and convinced the far-shooter, so that
 renown in her land should go to Telphusa herself and not to Apollo. (254–275)

APOLLO BUILDS HIS TEMPLE AT THE SITE OF DELPHI

From there you went further, far-shooting Apollo, and you reached the town of
 the hubristic people, the Phlegyae, who have no concern for Zeus and live on
 earth in a beautiful glen near the Cephisean lake. You darted away from here

quickly and came to mountain ridges and arrived at Crisa beneath snowy Mt. Parnassus. Its foothills turn towards the west, and its rocky cliffs hang from above over the hollow glade that stretches below. Here the lord Phoebus Apollo decreed that he would make his lovely temple and he said: "Here I intend to build a very beautiful temple, an oracle for mortals. Here all those who live in the rich Peloponnesus, in Europe, and on the sea-girt islands will bring perfect hecatombs and consult the oracle. To them I shall deliver my answers and ordain infallible counsel in my wealthy temple." (276–293) 80

Thus, Phoebus Apollo spoke and laid out the foundations, wide and very long overall. On these foundations Trophonius and Agamedes, the sons of Erginus, both dear to the immortal gods, placed a threshold of stone; and countless numbers of men built up with finished blocks of stone the temple, to sing about forever. There was a beautifully flowing spring nearby, where the lord, son of Zeus, killed with his mighty bow a she-dragon, a huge, bloated, and fierce monster who had done many evils to mortals on earth, to mortals themselves and to their thin-shanked flocks; for she was a bloodthirsty scourge. (294–304) 90

HERA GIVES BIRTH TO THE MONSTER TYPHAON

Once this she-dragon received, from golden-throned Hera to bring up, Typhaon, another terrible and cruel scourge for mortals;³⁶ this was when Hera became angry with father Zeus and gave birth to the monster because the son of Cronus bore renowned Athena from his head. Lady Hera was quickly enraged, and she spoke among the immortals: "Hear from me, all you gods and all you goddesses, how Zeus, the cloud-gatherer, first begins to dishonor me, when he has made me his dear and trusting wife. Apart from me, just now, he has given birth to keen-eyed Athena, who is outstanding among all the blessed immortals. But my son, Hephaestus, whom I myself bore, with his withered feet, was a weakling among the immortals—a shame to me and a disgrace on Olympus. I grabbed him myself with my own hands and threw him out, and he fell into the wide sea. But silver-footed Thetis, daughter of Nereus, accepted him and with her sisters took care of him. (How I wish that she had done some other favor for the blessed gods!) Villain, crafty deceiver, what other scheme will you devise now? How do you dare, all alone, to give birth to keen-eyed Athena? Would I not have borne a child by you? To be sure I was the one called your very own among the immortals who hold the wide heaven. Watch out now that I don't devise some evil for you in the future. Indeed, I will contrive how a son of mine will be born, who will be outstanding among the immortals, without any shame to our sacred marriage vow, either yours or mine. I shall not go near your bed, but separated from you I shall associate with the immortal gods." (305–330) 100

Thus she spoke and went apart from the gods, angered in her heart. Then straightway ox-eyed lady Hera prayed and struck the ground with the flat of her hand and uttered this invocation: "Earth and wide Heaven, hear me now, and you, Titan gods dwelling beneath the earth in vast Tartarus, from whom both mortals and gods are descended—all of you listen to me and give me, without Zeus as father, a child in no way inferior to him in might. But let him be as much stronger than Zeus as all-seeing Zeus is stronger than Cronus." Thus, she called out and lashed the ground with her mighty hand. The life-giving Earth was moved; and, when Hera saw this, she rejoiced in her heart. For she believed that her prayer would be answered. (331–342) 110

From this time then, for a whole year, Hera never approached the bed of wise Zeus, nor did she ever, as before, sit on her intricate throne and by his side devise shrewd plans. But ox-eyed lady Hera remained in her temples, filled with her worshipers, and took delight in their offerings. Yet when the months and days were completed and the seasons had passed as the full year came round, she gave birth to a terrible scourge for mortals, cruel Typhaon, like neither a god nor a human being. Ox-eyed lady Hera at once took and gave him, an evil, to the evil she-dragon, who accepted him, Typhaon, who used to inflict many sufferings on the renowned tribes of human beings. (343–355)

APOLLO VAUNTS OVER THE SHE-DRAGON HE HAS SLAIN

As for the she-dragon, whoever opposed her met the fatal day of death, until lord Apollo, the far-shooter, struck her with a mighty arrow. Racked by bitter pain, she lay gasping frantically for breath and writhing on the ground. An unspeakable and terrifying sound arose as she twisted and rolled in the forest; breathing out blood, she gave up her life, and Phoebus Apollo vaunted over her: (356–362)

“Now rot here on the ground that nourishes mortals. You shall not live any longer to be the evil ruin of human beings who eat the fruit of the all-fostering earth and who will bring perfect hecatombs to his place.” Thus he spoke, boasting; and darkness covered her eyes and the holy might of Helios caused her to rot there. Because of this, now the place is named Pytho, and they call its lord by the title, Pythian, since the mighty glare of the burning sun made the monster rot on the very spot. (363–374)

Then Phoebus Apollo knew in his heart why the beautifully flowing spring, Telphusa, had tricked him. In anger, he went to her and quickly he was there; standing very near her, he said: “Telphusa, you were not about to deceive my intelligence and keep this desirable place for you to put forth your beautifully flowing water. Here, to be sure, will be my glory, and not only yours.” He spoke and lord Apollo, the far-worker, pushed on top of her a massive shower of rocks and hid her flowing stream; and he built an altar in the forest grove very near her beautifully flowing fountain. There all pray to Apollo under the name Telphusian because he shamed the stream of holy Telphusa. (375–387)

APOLLO RECRUITS CRETANS TO SERVE AS HIS PRIESTS

Then Phoebus Apollo thought deeply about what people he would bring in as his priests who would serve him in rocky Pytho. While he was thinking this over, he noticed a swift ship on the wine-dark sea. On it were many fine men, Cretans from Minoan Cnossus, who perform sacrifices to their lord and make known the pronouncements of Phoebus Apollo of the golden sword, whatever oracle he gives from his laurel beneath the slopes of Parnassus. These men were sailing in their black ship to sandy Pylos and the people in Pylos for trade and profit. But Phoebus Apollo intercepted them on the sea and leaped onto their swift ship in the shape of a dolphin and lay there, a huge and dread monster. None



Apollo Delphinus. Attic red-figure hydria by the Berlin painter, ca. 480 B.C.; height 20 ½ in. Apollo rides over the sea in a winged tripod, as dolphins leap above the waves and fishes and an octopus swims below. He wears the laurel wreath and plays the lyre, while his bow and quiver are slung on his back. The artist brilliantly combines three aspects of Apollo, as prophet (symbolized by the Delphic tripod and the dolphins, associated with Delphi), musician, and archer. (Vatican Museums)



Audio

of the men understood, nor did they recognize the dolphin as the god, and they wanted to throw it overboard. But he kept making the entire ship quake and its timbers quiver. They were afraid and sat in silence on the hollow black ship; and they did not slacken the ropes or the sail of their dark-prowed ship. But as they had fixed their course by the oxhide ropes, so they sailed on, and a fierce south wind drove the swift ship from behind. (388–409) 170

First, they sailed by Malia and the coast of Laconia and came to Taenarum, a sea-crowned town, and the land of Heliuss, who makes mortals glad, where the thick-fleeced sheep of lord Heliuss pasture always and inhabit a pleasurable country.³⁷ They wanted to bring the ship ashore, disembark, and study the great marvel and watch with their own eyes whether the monster would remain on the deck of the hollow ship or leap back into the swell of the sea, full of fish. But the well-built ship did not obey their directions but made its way along the fertile Peloponnesus; lord Apollo, the far-worker, easily directed it with a breeze. The ship, continuing its course, came to Arena, lovely Argyphsea, and Thryon, the ford of the river Alpheus, and well-built Aepy and Pylos and the inhabitants of Pylos; and it went past Cruini and Chalcis and past Dyme and splendid Elis, where the Epei hold power. When it was sailing toward Pherae, jaunty in a wind from Zeus, beneath the clouds appeared the steep mountain of Ithaca and Dulichium and Same and wooded Zacynthus. But when it had passed the whole coast of the Peloponnesus, then to be sure, as they turned toward Crisa, there loomed before them the vast gulf whose length cuts off the rich Peloponnesus. A west wind, strong, clear, and vehement, came out of the sky by Zeus' decree and speeded the ship along so that it might complete its fast course over the briny water of the sea as quickly as possible. Then indeed they were sailing back toward the dawn and the sun. Lord Apollo, son of Zeus, was their guide, and they came to the conspicuous harbor of vine-clad Crisa, where the seafaring ship was grounded on the sands. (409–439) 180 190

There lord Apollo, the far-worker, leaped out of the ship like a star at midday. His person was engulfed by a shooting fiery shower, and his splendor reached to the heavens. He made his way, amidst precious tripods, to his innermost sanctuary. Then he caused a blaze to flare up and his arrows were bathed in a brilliance that encompassed the whole of Crisa. The wives and the lovely-dressed daughters of the Crisaeans cried out in amazement at the spectacular sight of Apollo; for the god instilled an awesome fear in each of them. Thereupon, swift as thought, he made a flying leap back onto the ship, in the form of a man in his prime, strong and vigorous, with his hair flowing about his broad shoulders. Uttering winged words, he spoke to them. (440–451) 200

"Strangers, who are you? From where do you sail the watery paths? Is barter your goal, or do you roam recklessly, like pirates over the deep, who hazard their lives as they wander bringing evil to strangers? Why do you sit this way, despondent? Why don't you disembark and take your gear from your black ship to land? This is the right thing for enterprising men to do whenever they come from the sea to shore in their black ship; they are worn out and weary and straightway overcome by the desire for luscious food." (452–461) 210

Thus he spoke and put spirit in their breasts, and the leader of the Cretans said in answer: "Stranger, indeed you do not look at all like mortals in your appearance and stature, but like the immortal gods. Good health and all hail, may the gods give you prosperity! Tell me this truly so that I may understand fully: What territory, what land is this? What people live here? For we were sailing the great seas, with other intentions, bound for Pylos from Crete, where we are

proud to have been born; yet now we have arrived here with our ship, in a different way and by another course, not at all willingly, and anxious to return; but someone of the immortals has taken us here, against our wishes.” (462–473) 220

Then Apollo, the far-worker, spoke in answer: “Strangers, who used to live in wooded Cnossus before, now no longer will you return again to your lovely city, beautiful homes, and dear wives; but each of you here will keep my rich temple, honored by many mortals. I say proudly that I am Apollo, son of Zeus, and I took you to this place over the wide expanse of the sea. I intend you no harm, but you will keep my rich temple here, greatly esteemed and honored by all human beings; and you will know the counsels of the immortals, by whose will you always will be honored continually all your days. But come, as quickly as possible obey me in what I say. First let down the sails and loosen the ropes of ox-hide; then draw the swift ship up from the water onto dry land and remove your possessions and gear 230 from the well-balanced ship; and build an altar on the shore of the sea; and, kindling a fire, make an offering of white barley. Then pray, standing around the altar. As I first leaped aboard your swift ship on the hazy sea in the form of a dolphin, so pray to me as Delphinus; furthermore, the altar itself will be Delphinus and overlooking³⁸ forever. Next, take your meal by the swift black ship and make a libation to the blessed gods who hold Olympus. But when you have satisfied your desire for luscious food, come with me and sing the *Ie Paeon* (Hail Healer) until the time when you arrive at the place where you will keep my rich temple.” (474–501)

So Apollo spoke, and they readily listened to him and obeyed. First, they let down the sails and loosened the ropes of ox-hide; and, lowering the mast by 240 the forestays, they brought it to rest on the mast-holder. They themselves disembarked on the seashore and drew the swift ship up from the water onto dry land. They built an altar on the shore of the sea; and, kindling a fire, they made an offering of white barley; and they prayed, as he ordered, standing around the altar. Then they took their meal by the swift black ship and made a libation to the blessed gods who hold Olympus. But when they had satisfied their desire for food and drink, they got up and went with their leader, lord Apollo the son of Zeus, who held his lyre in his hands and played a lovely tune, as he stepped high and stately. The Cretans followed, marching to his rhythm, and they sang the *Ie Paeon*, like the Cretan *paeon* singers and those in whose breasts the divine 250 Muse has placed sweet song. (502–519)

With weariless feet, they reached the mountain-ridge and quickly arrived at Parnassus itself and the desirable place where they were going to live, honored by human beings. Apollo, who had led them there, pointed out his sacred sanctuary and rich temple. And the spirit was aroused in their dear breasts; and the leader of the Cretans questioned him with these words: “O lord, since you have brought us far from our loved ones and our fatherland—so was it somehow your wish—how then shall we live now? This we ask you to explain. This place is desirable neither as a vineyard nor as a pasture.” (520–530)

And Apollo, the son of Zeus, smiling upon them, said: “Foolish, wretched 260 mortals, who prefer heartfelt care, hard work, and trouble; I shall give you a message of comfort, and take it in earnest. Even if each of you, holding a knife in his right hand, were to slaughter sheep continuously, still the supply would not be exhausted with all that the renowned tribes of human beings bring to me here. Guard my temple and receive the human hordes who gather here, and above all point out to them my directions and keep my ordinances in your hearts. But if anyone is foolish enough to pay no heed and disobey, if there will be any idle word

or deed or hubris, which is usually the case among mortal humans, then other men will be masters over you and you will be forced to submit to their might all your days. Everything has been told to you; store it in your hearts.” (531–544)

So farewell, son of Zeus and Leto. Yet I shall remember you and another song too. 270

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Primary Sources

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Homer	<i>Iliad</i> 1.43–52
Homeric Hymn 3a	<i>To Delian Apollo</i>
Homeric Hymn 3b	<i>To Pythian Apollo</i>
Homeric Hymn 16	<i>To Asclepius</i>
Homeric Hymn 21	<i>To Apollo</i>
Ovid	<i>Metamorphoses</i> 1.452–567; 2.600–634; 6.385–400; 10.174–219; 11.146–193; 14.132–153
Vergil	<i>Aeneid</i> 6.42–51; 77–82; 98–101

Additional Sources

Aristophanes	<i>Plutus</i> (Wealth, a blind beggar, is healed through incubation)
Asclepius	<i>Alcesteis</i>
Euripides	<i>Ion</i>

Lucian *of the Gods: Hermes and Apollo*
 Pausanias *Description of Greece* 2.26.1–2.29.1: Epidaurus and Asclepius;
 5.10.8: The Olympia pediment: Battle between Lapiths and
 Centaurs (Note that Pausanias identifies Apollo as Pirithoüs.)

DVDs

Opera: Strauss, Richard (1864–1949). *Daphne*. Anderson et al. Venice Teatro la Fenice Orchestra, cond. Reck. Strauss' dynamic operatic version of the myth is an amalgamation of Ovid and Pausanias. The ecstatic final scene brilliantly evokes Daphne's transformation into a laurel tree. Some, however, may find the staging and direction of this production disappointing. The final scene is available on CD performed by many singers, including Renée Fleming, who also has made a recording of the complete opera.

Opera: Gluck, Christoph Willibald (1718–1787). *Alceste*. von Otter et al. English Baroque soloists, cond. Gardiner. Image Entertainment. Also Naglestad et al. Staatsoper Stuttgart, cond. Carydis. Arthaus Musik. Both of these modern productions are very controversial in their theatrical presentations of this most beautiful but static opera, the first staged by Robert Wilson, the second updated to modern times by Jossi Wieler. Both use the French (Paris) extensively revised version (1776), much preferred to the original (1767), which has no scene with Hercules. There are many recorded performances on CD with notable singers (e.g., Flagstad, Callas, Norman, and Baker, not to mention the tenors).

Ballet: *Apollo*. Choreography by George Balanchine. Music by Igor Stravinsky. In *Jacques D'Amboise: Portrait of a Great American Dancer*. VAI. At last, a complete performance on DVD. Among the other ballets D'Amboise performs is *Afternoon of a Faun*, choreographed by Jerome Robbins, with music by Debussy. See Chapter 28 on the companion website.

Song: Strauss, Richard (1864–1949). "Gesang der Apollonpriesterin" ("Song of the Priestess of Apollo"). Text by Emanuel von Bodman. On *Renée Fleming: Lieder*. Wiener Philharmoniker, cond. Thielemann. Opus Arte. Also included are two other selections by Strauss: *An Alpine Symphony (Eine Alpensymphonie)* and the last scene from his opera *Arabella*. This is one of Strauss' best songs and is not as performed or recorded as often as it should be. On CD, the "Song of the Priestess of Apollo" is included on recordings of recitals by Evelyn Lear, Karita Mattila, Adrienne Pieczonka, Michaela Kaune, and Rose Pauly.

Documentary: *Delphi Center of the World*. A film by Frieder Käsmann, Kultur. Excellent, interesting photography of the site itself and its architecture and sculpture.

Notes

1. Many had cults of Apollo. Leto's wanderings are at times geographically erratic. Most of the places mentioned are familiar enough, but some names are problematical. Any attempt to trace Leto's wanderings precisely should begin with the notes in *The Homeric Hymns*, ed. T. W. Allen, W. R. Halliday, and E. E. Sikes, 2d ed. (New York: Oxford University Press, 1963).
2. In later accounts, Hera employs various schemes to prevent Leto from finding a place to bear her children, and through fear of Hera the whole earth rejects Leto's pleas. Hera also is said to have decreed that Leto's children could not be born in any place where the sun shone, so Poseidon kept the island of Delos (which in this early time was afloat) covered by his waves from the sun's rays during the birth of the twins.

3. These lines were thought to refer to Homer, who, among the many traditions, becomes a blind bard from the island of Chios. It is extremely unlikely that the Homer associated with the *Iliad* and *Odyssey* wrote this hymn or any of the others. Bards are archetypically blind as opposed to the hale and hearty politicians and warriors; in terms of another fundamental motif, blind poets see the Muses' truth.
4. It is not difficult to imagine a fluid bardic tradition in which hymns could vary in length and be presented in diverse combinations.
5. In later accounts, the dragon or serpent is sometimes masculine with the name Python (as in Ovid's story of Apollo and Daphne, translated later in this chapter). It may also be described as the hostile opponent of Leto before the birth of her children. Some versions stress the great prowess of Apollo early in his life and career (as in the case of the wondrous childhood of Hermes and Heracles) to the extent of having him kill the dragon while still a child.
6. Aeschylus in the prologue to his *Eumenides* and Euripides in a chorus from his *Iphigenia in Tauris*. A scholarly survey of the problems, with a reconstruction of the origins and procedures of the oracle, is provided by H. W. Parke and D. E. W. Wormell, *The Delphic Oracle*, 2 vols. (Oxford: Blackwell, 1956).
7. A festival (called the Stepteria) was celebrated every ninth year at Delphi to commemorate these events in the early history of the sanctuary.
8. The omphalos found in the excavations and originally identified as the archaic sacred stone has subsequently been labeled a fraud.
9. The other major Panhellenic festivals were those at Olympia and Nemea, both in honor of Zeus, and the Isthmian Games at Corinth, dedicated to Poseidon.
10. For the oracular Apollo elsewhere, see H. W. Parke, *The Oracles of Apollo in Asia Minor* (London: Croom Helm, 1985); also Joseph Fontenrose, *Didyma: Apollo's Oracle, Cult, and Companions* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1988), who is overly skeptical in his scholarly treatment of evidence.
11. One could inquire on one's own behalf or on the behalf of someone else. Inquiries often came from state representatives. Both the question and the answer were usually set down in writing. See Joseph Fontenrose, *The Delphic Oracle: Its Responses and Operations* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1978).
12. Among the religious objects that decked the temple was the tomb of Dionysus. The god Dionysus was worshiped alongside Apollo in the sanctuary (perhaps as early as the sixth century). The prophetic trance of the Pythia has something in common with Dionysiac frenzy. See Walter Burkert, *Ancient Mystery Cults* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1987), p. 108.
13. The first Pythia, who is named Phemonoë (Prophetic Mind), is a poetic figure; we have from Herodotus the names of later ones (Aristonice and Perallus), historically much more real.
14. Diodorus Siculus, 16.26; Plutarch *Moralia*, "Oracles in Decline," 435d; and Pausanias 10.5.7.
15. J. Z. De Boer and J. R. Hale, "The Geological Origins of the Oracle at Delphi, Greece," in *The Archaeology of Geological Catastrophies*, W. G. McGuire et al., eds., *Geological Society Special Publication* no. 171 (London 2000), pp. 399–412; J. Z. De Boer, J. R. Hale, and J. Chanton, "New Evidence of Geological Origins of the Ancient Delphic Oracle (Greece)," *Geology* 29 (2001), pp. 707–710. J. Z. De Boer and J. R. Hale, "Was She Really Stoned? The Oracle of Delphi," *Archaeological Odyssey* 5 (Nov./Dec. 2002), pp. 46–53, 58–59.
16. W. J. Broad, *The Oracle: The Lost Secrets and Hidden Message of Ancient Delphi* (New York: Penguin Press, 2006), pp. 240–241; and Michael Attyah Flower, *The Seer in Ancient Greece* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2008), pp. 227–230. See also Joan Breton Connelly, *Portrait of a Priestess: Women and Ritual in Ancient Greece* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press), pp. 72–81.
17. See H. W. Parke, *Sibyls and Sibylline Prophecy in Classical Antiquity*, ed. Brian C. McGing. Croom Helm Classical Studies (New York: Routledge, 1988).

18. This Sibyl is Deïphobe, daughter of Glaucus, priestess of the temple of Phoebus Apollo and Diana.
19. Vergil's works themselves were consulted as oracles in later times as the *sortes Vergilianae*.
20. A total of one thousand years, counting the generations (*saecula*) as one hundred years each.
21. Petronius, *Satyricon* 48. 8. The Sibyl's story appears to be late in its reminiscences of Cassandra and Tithonus.
22. This is the Aristaeus who will become the husband of Autonoë and father of Actaeon; he, too, is the one who made advances to Eurydice. He is particularly linked with agricultural pursuits, especially beekeeping.
23. For the theme of homosexuality, see pp. 22–23.
24. Ovid puts the story in the mouth of Orpheus. Other accounts have Zephyrus (the West Wind) deliberately divert the course of the discus because of his jealous love for Hyacinthus.
25. These marks not only reproduce Apollo's moans of grief, they are also the initial letters of the name of the hero of the Trojan saga, the great Ajax (Greek *Aias*), son of Telamon, as Apollo indicates in his prophetic words. When Ajax committed suicide, the same flower, the hyacinth, sprang from his blood (Ovid, *Metamorphoses* 13. 391–398).
26. See Glenn W. Geelhoed, "The Caduceus as a Medical Emblem: Heritage or Heresy?" *Southern Medical Journal* 81, no. 9 (September 1988), pp. 1155–1161. See also by an account executive (not a doctor), Paul T. Frett, "Medicine's Identity Crisis Revealed: The Asclepius vs. the Caduceus" *Minnesota Medicine* 77 (October 1994), pp. 48–50. He argues for the Asclepius staff.
27. See Emma J. Edelstein and Ludwig Edelstein, *Asclepius: A Collection and Interpretation of the Testimonies* (Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1998 [1945]) and E. R. Dodds, *The Greeks and the Irrational* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1951).
28. This is the famous Midas of the golden touch (Ovid's version of his story, *Metamorphoses* 11. 85–145, is well known). His story is told in Chapter 13, pp. 322–323.
29. Elements of folktale appear dominant in this story, particularly in the traditional depiction of the garrulous barber. In some versions, Midas plays this same role in the contest between Apollo and Marsyas. Thus, he favors the satyr against Apollo and suffers the same humiliation.
30. Apollo's epithet Lykios was believed by the Greeks to mean "wolf-god," whatever this may signify—that he was a hunter like a wolf? That he was the protector against the wolf? Perhaps Lykios is to be derived from Lycia, a district in southwestern Asia Minor.
31. Johann Joachim Winckelmann, *History of the Art of Antiquity*, trans. Harry Francis Mallgrave (Los Angeles: Getty Research Institute, 2006), pp. 333–334.
32. These lines about Apollo as a suitor are full of problems; the text seems to be corrupt. Ischys and Apollo vied for Coronis, and Leucippus and Apollo vied for Daphne (in a version given by Pausanias, 8.20.3). Nothing much can be made of the other rivals.
33. Apollo's itinerary offers some geographical problems, but in general he goes from Olympus through Larissa (the home of the Perrhaebi) to Iolcus and eventually crosses to the Lelantine plain (between Chalcis and Eretria) on the island of Euboea, and then back again to the mainland and Onchestus, Thebes, Lake Copais, and the Cephissus River—all in Boeotia. Next, continuing westward, Apollo comes to the spring Telphusa in the region of Mt. Helicon, and from there finally to Crisa, the site of his Delphi.
34. This is our only evidence for this ritual in honor of Poseidon at his famous precinct in Onchestus, and the numerous conjectures made by scholars about its meaning and purpose are not at all convincing.
35. Some etymologists do not agree with the ancients, who thought this name was derived from the cry *le* and *Paean*, meaning "healer." Later in this hymn, it is the name of a song.

36. *Typhaon* is also the name of the monster killed by Zeus, that is, Typhoeus or Typhaon or Typhon; see p. 84.
37. The ship sails along the south coast of the Peloponnesus, then up the north coast until it turns into the Corinthian gulf and makes for Crisa.
38. The Greek word translated as “overlooking” is *epopsios* and may refer to another epithet of Apollo (and Zeus) as “overseers” of everything; or the adjective may only mean that the altar is “conspicuous.”

For additional resources related to this chapter, go to
www.oup.com/us/morford.

Hermes

The messenger, the slayer of Argos, did not disobey. He immediately put on his feet the beautiful sandals, immortal and golden, which carried him upon the waters and over the boundless earth swift as a breath of wind. He took his staff with which he enchants the eyes of those whom he wishes and rouses those who slumber.

—HOMER, *Odyssey* 5.43–48

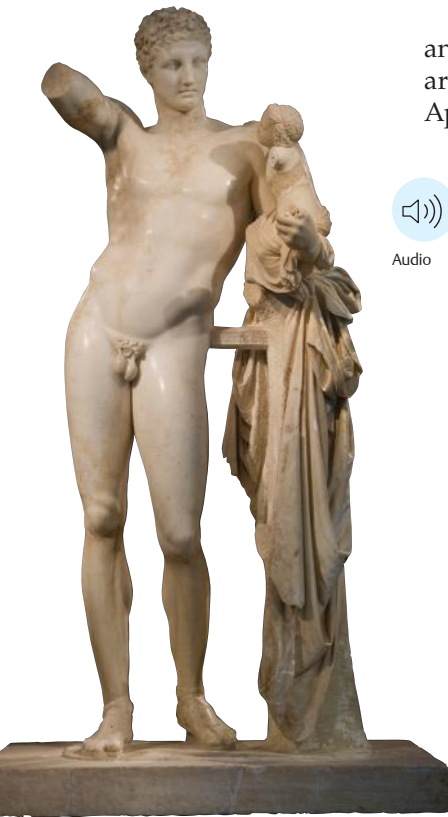
The Birth and Childhood of Hermes

The *Homeric Hymn to Hermes* (18) concentrates on the story (repeated at the beginning of the much more lengthy and important hymn that follows) of how Zeus became the father of Hermes as the result of his union with **Maia**, one of the Pleiades, the daughters of Atlas and Pleione.

I sing about Hermes, the Cyllenian slayer of Argus, lord of Mt. Cyllene and Arcadia rich in flocks, the messenger of the gods and bringer of luck, whom Maia, the daughter of Atlas, bore, after uniting in love with Zeus. She in her modesty shunned the company of the blessed gods and lived in a shadowy cave; here the son of Cronus used to make love to this nymph of the beautiful hair in the dark of night, without the knowledge of immortal gods and mortal humans, when sweet sleep held white-armed Hera fast. (1–9)

So hail to you, son of Zeus and Maia. After beginning with you, I shall turn to another hymn. Hail, Hermes, guide and giver of grace 10 and other good things.





Hermes and the Infant Dionysus, by Praxiteles, ca. 340 B.C.; height 82 in. The Greek author Pausanias saw this statue in the temple of Hera at Olympia in the mid-second century A.D. and named its sculptor. It is possible that the present statue is an ancient copy of the one that Pausanias saw, which may have been damaged and replaced. The infant Dionysus is reaching for a bunch of grapes held in the (missing) right hand of Hermes, whose left hand originally held his caduceus. The white Parian marble is highly polished, and the off-center weight of the figures is supported by the tree trunk, which is largely concealed by Hermes' cloak. (Vanni/Art Resource, NY)



Audio

The more famous *Homeric Hymn to Hermes* (4) tells the story of the god's birth and childhood with delightful charm and disarming candor. Here is a most artful depiction of this mischievous divine child, who invents the lyre and steals Apollo's cattle:

Sing, O Muse, of the son of Zeus and Maia, lord of Mt. Cyllene and Arcadia rich in flocks, the messenger of the gods and bringer of luck, whom Maia of the beautiful hair bore after uniting in love with Zeus. She in her modesty shunned the company of the blessed gods and lived within a shadowy cave; here the son of Cronus joined in love with this nymph of the beautiful hair in the dark of night, without the knowledge of immortal gods and mortal humans, while sweet sleep held white-armed Hera fast. But when the will of Zeus had been accomplished and her tenth month was fixed in the heavens, she brought forth to the light a child, and a remarkable thing was accomplished; for the child whom she bore was devious, winning in his cleverness, a robber, a driver of cattle, a guide of dreams, a spy in the night, a watcher at the door, who soon was about to manifest renowned deeds among the immortal gods. (1–16) 10

Maia bore him on the fourth day of the month. He was born at dawn, by midday he was playing the lyre, and in the evening he stole the cattle of far-shooting Apollo. After he leaped forth from the immortal limbs of his mother, he did not remain lying in his sacred cradle; but he sprang up and looked for the cattle of Apollo. When he crossed the threshold of the high-roofed cave, he found a tortoise and obtained boundless pleasure from it. (17–24)

HERMES INVENTS THE LYRE

Indeed, Hermes was the very first to make the tortoise a minstrel. He happened to meet it in the very entranceway, waddling along as it ate the luxurious grass in front of the dwelling. When Zeus' son, the bringer of luck, saw it, he laughed and said at once: "Already a very good omen for me; I shall not be scornful. Greetings; what a delight you appear to me, lovely in shape, graceful in movement and a good dinner companion. Where did you, a tortoise living in the mountains, get this speckled shell that you have on, a beautiful plaything? Come, I shall take you and bring you inside. You will be of some use to me, and I shall do you no dishonor. You will be the very first to be an advantage to me, but a better one inside, since the out-of-doors is dangerous for you. To be sure, while you are alive you will continue to be a charm against evil witchcraft, but if you were dead, then you would make very beautiful music."¹ (25–38) 20

Thus he spoke and lifted the tortoise in both hands and went back into his dwelling carrying the lovely plaything. Then he cut up the mountain-dwelling tortoise and scooped out its life-marrow with a knife of gray iron. As swiftly as a thought darts through the mind of a man whose cares come thick and fast or as a twinkle flashes from the eye, thus glorious Hermes devised his plan and carried it out simultaneously. He cut to size stocks of reeds, extended them across the back and through the tortoise shell and fastened them securely. In his ingenuity, he stretched the hide of an ox all around and affixed two arms to which he attached a bridge, and then he extended seven tuneful strings of sheep gut. (39–51) 30

When he had finished, he took up the lovely plaything and tried it by striking successive notes. It resounded in startling fashion under his hand, and the god accompanied his playing with a beautiful song, improvising at random just as 40

young men exchange banter on a festive occasion. He sang about Zeus, the son of Cronus, Maia with the beautiful sandals, and their talk in the intimacy of their love, and proclaimed aloud the renown of his birth. He honored, too, the handmaids of the nymph, her splendid home, and the tripods and the ample cauldrons it contained. He sang of these things, but his heart was set on other pursuits. He took the hollow lyre and set it down in his sacred cradle; for he craved for meat and leaped out of the fragrant hall to a place where he could watch, since he was devising in his heart sheer trickery such as men who are 50 thieves plan in the dead of black night. (52–67)

HERMES STEALS APOLLO'S CATTLE

Helios, the Sun, with his horses and chariot was descending to earth and the stream of Ocean, when Hermes came hurrying to the shady mountains of Pieria² where the immortal cattle of the blessed gods have their home, grazing on the lovely untouched meadows. The sharp-sighted son of Maia, the slayer of Argus, cut off from the herd fifty loud-bellowing cattle and drove them over sandy ground, reversing their tracks as they wandered. For he did not forget his skill at trickery, and he made their hoofs go backward, the front ones last and the back ones first; he himself walked straight ahead. For quickly, by the sandy seashore, he wove sandals of wicker, a wonderful achievement, beyond 60 description and belief; he combined twigs of myrtle and tamarisk and fastened together bundles of the freshly sprouting wood which he bound, leaves and all, under his feet as light sandals. The glorious slayer of Argus made them so, as he left Pieria, improvising since he was hastening over a long journey.³ (68–86)

But an old man, who was working in a luxuriant vineyard, noticed him coming to the plain through Onchestus with its beds of grass. The renowned son of Maia spoke to him first: “Old man, digging about with stooped shoulders, you will indeed have much wine when all these vines bear fruit, if you listen to me and earnestly remember in your heart to be blind to what you have seen and deaf to what you have heard and to keep silent, since nothing of your own has 70 been harmed in any way.” He said only this much and pushed the sturdy head of cattle on together. Glorious Hermes drove them over many shady mountains, echoing hollows, and flowery plains. (87–96)

The greater part of divine night, his dark helper, was over; and the break of day that calls men to work was soon coming on, and bright Selene, daughter of lord Pallas, the son of Megamedes,⁴ had climbed to a new watchpost, when the strong son of Zeus drove the broad-browed cattle of Phoebus Apollo to the river Alpheus. They were unwearied when they came to the lofty shelter and the watering places that faced the splendid meadow. Then, when he had fed the loud-bellowing cattle well on fodder, he drove them all together into the shelter, 80 as they ate lotus and marsh plants covered with dew. He gathered together a quantity of wood and pursued, with diligent passion, the skill of producing fire. He took a good branch of laurel and trimmed it with his knife, and in the palm of his hand he grasped a piece of wood; and the hot breath of fire rose up.⁵ Indeed, Hermes was the very first to invent fire sticks and fire. He took many dry sticks which he left as they were and heaped them up together in a pit in the ground. The flame shone forth, sending afar a great blaze of burning fire. (97–114)

While the power of renowned Hephaestus was kindling the fire, Hermes dragged outside near the blaze two horned cattle, bellowing, for much strength

went with him. He threw them both, panting upon their backs, onto the ground and bore down upon them. Rolling them over, he pierced through their life's marrow; he followed up this work with more, cutting the meat rich in fat and spearing the pieces with wooden spits, and roasted all together the flesh, choice parts from the back, and the bowels that enclosed the black blood. He laid these pieces on the ground and stretched the hides on a rugged rock, and thus still even now they are there continually long afterward, despite the interval of time. Next Hermes in the joy of his heart whisked the rich bundles away to a smooth flat rock and divided them into twelve portions that he allotted, adding a choice piece to each, making it wholly an honorable offering. (115–129) 90

Then glorious Hermes longed for the sacred meat of the sacrifice, for the sweet aroma made him weak, even though he was an immortal. But his noble heart did not yield, although his desire was overwhelming to gulp the offering down his holy throat.⁶ But he quickly put the fat and all the meat away in the cave with its lofty roof, setting them up high as a testimony of his recent childhood theft, and he gathered up wood for the fire and destroyed all the hoofs and the heads in the blaze. When the god had accomplished all that he had to do, he threw his sandals into the deep-eddy stream of the Alpheus; he put out the embers and hid the black ashes in the sand. Thus he spent the whole night as the beautiful light of Selene shone down on him. Swiftly then he went back to the divine peaks of Cyllene and encountered no one at all (neither blessed gods nor mortal humans) on his long journey, and dogs did not bark. (130–145) 100 110

Hermes, the luck-bringer, son of Zeus, slipped sideways past the lock into his house, like the gust of a breeze in autumn, and went directly through the cave to his luxurious inner chamber, stepping gently on his feet, for he did not make a sound as one would walking upon the floor. Glorious Hermes quickly got into his cradle and wrapped the blankets about his shoulders like a helpless baby and lay toying with his fingers at the covers on his knees; at his left side he kept his beloved lyre close by his hand. (145–154)

But the god did not escape the notice of his goddess mother, who spoke to him: “You devious rogue, in your cloak of shameless guile, where in the world have you come from in the nighttime? Now I am convinced that either Apollo, son of Leto, by his own hands will drag you with your sides bound fast right out the door, or you will prowl about the valleys, a robber and a cheat. Be gone then! Your father begat you as a great trouble for mortals and immortal gods!” (155–161) 120

Hermes answered her with clever words: “Mother, why do you throw this up at me, as to a helpless child who knows in his heart very little of evil, a fearful baby, frightened of his mother’s chiding? But I shall set upon whatever work is best to provide for me and you together. We two shall not endure to stay here in this place alone, as you bid, apart from the immortals without gifts and prayers. Better all our days to live among the gods, rich and full in wealth and plenty, than to sit at home in the shadows of this cave! And I shall go after divine honor just as Apollo has. And if my father does not give it to me, to be sure I shall take my honor myself (and I can do it) which is to be the prince of thieves. And if the glorious son of Leto search me out, I think he will meet with another even greater loss. For I shall go to Pytho and break right into his great house, and I shall seize from within plenty of very beautiful tripods and bowls and gold and gleaming iron and an abundance of clothing. You will be able to see it all, if you like.” Thus they conversed with each other, the son of aegis-bearing Zeus and the lady Maia. (162–183) 130

APOLLO CONFRONTS HERMES

As Eos, the early-born, sprang up from the deep-flowing waters of Ocean, 140 bringing light to mortals, Apollo was on his way and came to Onchestus, a very lovely grove sacred to loud-roaring Poseidon, who surrounds the earth. There he found the old man, who on the path within was feeding the animal that guarded his vineyard. The glorious son of Leto spoke to him first: "Old man, who pulls the weeds and briars of grassy Onchestus, I have come here from Pieria looking for some cattle from my herd—all cows, all with curved horns. The bull, which was black, fed alone away from the others; keen-eyed dogs followed behind, four of them, of one mind like humans. They were left behind, both the dogs and the bull—a truly amazing feat. But just as the sun had set, the cows went out of the soft meadow away from the sweet pasture. 150 Tell me this, old fellow, have you seen a man passing along the road with these cows?" (184–200)

The old man spoke to him in answer: "My friend, it is hard to tell everything that one sees with one's eyes. For many wayfarers pass along the road; some travel intent on much evil, others on much good. To know each of them is difficult. But, good sir, the whole day long until the sun set I was digging about in my fruitful vineyard and I thought that I noticed a child, I do not know for sure; whoever the child was, he, an infant, tended the fine-horned cattle and he had a stick. He walked from side to side as he drove them backward and kept their heads facing him." (201–211) 160



Audio



Closer Look



Hermes in Crib with Zeus, Apollo, and Maia. Black-figure hydria, from Caere (Cerveteri), ca. 500 B.C.; 17 in. in height. This vase is one of a number of vases known as *Caeretan Hydrias*, which represent a similar style of treatment and craftsmanship. Most of these vases have been discovered at Caere in Southern Etruria in Italy, hence the name. One of the marked features of the style is a playful sense of humor, which is perfectly suited to recount the exploits of the infant Hermes. Just behind Apollo are the stolen cattle, shielded from the main scene by a tree with luxuriant foliage. Apollo delivers his accusations against the baby Hermes, snugly nestled in his crib, to an indulgent Zeus and Maia, who defend him. (Left: *Réunion des Musées Nationaux/Art Resource, NY*) (Right: *Erich Lessing/Art Resource, NY*)



Closer Look

Thus the old man spoke; after Apollo had heard his tale, he went more quickly on his way. He noticed a bird with its wings extended, and from this sign he knew at once that the thief was a child born of Zeus, the son of Cronus. So lord Apollo, the son of Zeus, eagerly hastened to holy Pylos in search of his shambling cows, his broad shoulders enshrouded in a dark cloud. When the archer-god spied the tracks, he cried out: "Why, indeed, here is a great marvel that I see with my eyes. These are definitely the tracks of straight-horned cows, but they are turned backward toward the asphodel meadow. And these here are not the prints of a man or a woman or gray wolves or bears or lions; nor are they, I expect, those of a shaggy-maned centaur or whoever makes such monstrous strides with its swift feet. On this side of the road the tracks are strange, but on the other side they are even stranger." (212–226) 170

With these words lord Apollo, the son of Zeus, hurried on and came to the forest-clad mountain of Cyllene and the deeply shaded cave in the rock where the immortal nymph bore the child of Zeus, the son of Cronus. A lovely odor pervaded the sacred mountain, and many sheep ranged about grazing on the grass. Then the archer-god, Apollo himself, hurried over the stone threshold down into the shadowy cave. (227–234)

When the son of Zeus and Maia perceived that far-shooting Apollo was in a rage about his cattle, he sank down into his fragrant blankets. As ashes hide a bed of embers on logs of wood, so Hermes buried himself in his covers when he saw the archer-god. He huddled head and hands and feet tightly together as though just bathed and ready for sweet sleep, but he was really wide awake, and under his arm he held his lyre. The son of Zeus and Leto knew both the beautiful mountain nymph and her dear son, the little boy enveloped in craft and deceit, and he was not fooled. He looked in every corner of the great house. He took a shining key and opened three chambers full of nectar and lovely ambrosia, and in them, too, lay stored much silver and gold and many of the nymph's garments, rich in their hues of purple and silver, such as are found in the sacred dwellings of the blessed gods. (235–251) 180 190

Then, when the son of Leto had searched every nook in the great house, he addressed glorious Hermes with these words: "You, O child, lying in the cradle, inform me about my cattle and be quick, or soon the two of us will be at variance and it will not be nice. For I shall take hold of you and hurl you down into the terrible and irrevocable darkness of murky Tartarus; neither your mother nor your father will release you to the light above, but you will wander under the earth, a leader among little people." (252–259)

Hermes answered him craftily: "Son of Leto, what are these harsh words you have spoken? Have you come here looking for cattle of the field? I have not seen a thing, I do not know a thing, I have not heard a word from anyone. I cannot give information nor can I win the reward. Do I look like a man of brawn, a cattle rustler? That is not my line; I am interested rather in other things: sleep, milk from my mother's breast, baby blankets about my shoulders and warm baths. Do not let anyone find out how this dispute came about. It would indeed be a source of great amazement among the immortals that a newborn child should bring cattle of the field right through the front door of his house. What you say is pretty unlikely. I was born yesterday, my feet are tender and the ground is rough beneath them. If you wish, I shall swear a great oath by the head of my father; I pledge a vow that I am not guilty myself and that I have not seen anyone else who might be the one who stole your cows—whatever cows are, for I have only heard about them now for the first time." (260–277) 200 210

Thus Hermes spoke, his eyes twinkling and his brows raised as he looked all about, and gave a long whistle to show how fruitless he considered Apollo's quest. But far-shooting Apollo laughed softly and spoke to him: "Oh splendid, you sly-hearted cheat; from the way that you talk I am sure that many a time you have broken into the better homes during the night and reduced more than one poor fellow to extremities by grabbing everything in the house without a sound. And you will distress many a shepherd in the mountain glens, when greedy after meat you come upon their herds of cattle and their woolly sheep. But come on now, if you do not want to sleep your last and longest sleep, get down out of your cradle, you comrade of black night. For this then you will have as your prerogative hereafter among the gods: you will be called forevermore the prince of thieves." (278–292) 220

Thus Phoebus Apollo spoke and took hold of the child to carry him away. At that very moment, the mighty slayer of Argus had an idea; as he was being lifted in Apollo's hands he let go an omen, a bold and servile messenger from his belly, a hearty blast, and right after it he gave a violent sneeze. And when Apollo heard, he dropped glorious Hermes out of his hands to the ground and sat in front of him; even though he was eager to be on his way he spoke with taunting words: "Rest assured, son of Zeus and Maia, in your swaddling clothes, with these omens I shall find my sturdy head of cattle by and by, and furthermore you will lead the way." Thus he spoke. (293–304) 230

HERMES AND APOLLO BRING THEIR CASE BEFORE ZEUS

And Cyllenian Hermes gave a start and jumped up pushing the blanket away from both his ears with his hands, and clutching it around his shoulders he cried out: "Where are you taking me, O far-shooter, most vehement of all the gods? Is it because of the cows that you are so angry and assault me? Oh, oh, how I wish the whole breed of cattle might perish! For I did not steal your cows and I have not seen anyone else who has—whatever cows are, for I have only heard about them now for the first time. Let us have the case decided before Zeus, the son of Cronus." (304–312) 240

Thus, as they quarreled over each and every point, Hermes, the shepherd, and the splendid son of Leto remained divided. The latter spoke the truth and not without justice seized upon glorious Hermes because of the cattle; on the other hand, the Cyllenian wished to deceive the god of the silver bow by tricks and by arguments. But when he in his ingenuity found his opponent equally resourceful, he hastened to walk over the sandy plain in front with the son of Zeus and Leto behind. Quickly these two very beautiful children of Zeus came to their father, the son of Cronus, on the top of fragrant Olympus. For there the scales of justice lay ready for them both. (313–324)

A happy throng occupied snow-capped Olympus, for the deathless gods had assembled with the coming of golden-throned Dawn. Hermes and Apollo of the silver bow stood before the knees of Zeus, and he who thunders from on high spoke to his glorious son with the question: "Phoebus, where did you capture this delightful booty, a child newly born who has the appearance of a herald? This is a serious business that has come before the assembly of the gods." (325–332) 250

Then lord Apollo, the archer, replied: "O father, you, who scoff at me for being the only one who is fond of booty, are now going to hear a tale that is irrefutable. After journeying for a long time in the mountains of Cyllene I found a child, this

out-and-out robber here; as sharp a rogue I have not seen either among gods or 260
 mortals who cheat their fellows on earth. He stole my cows from the meadow in
 the evening and proceeded to drive them along the shore of the loud-sounding
 sea making directly for Pylos. The tracks were of two kinds, strange and marvel-
 ous, the work of a clever spirit. The black dust retained the prints of the cattle
 and showed them leading into the asphodel meadow. But this rogue I have
 here, an inexplicable wonder, did not cross the sandy ground on his feet or
 on his hands; but by some other means he smeared the marks of his amazing
 course as though someone had walked on oak saplings. As long as he followed
 the cattle across the sandy ground, the tracks stood out very clearly in the dust.
 But when he had covered the great stretch of sand, his own course and that of 270
 the cows quickly became imperceptible on the hard ground. But a mortal man
 noticed him driving the herd of cattle straight for Pylos. When he had quietly
 penned up the cows and slyly confused his homeward trail by zigzagging this
 way and that, he nestled down in his cradle, obscure as the black night, within
 the darkness of the gloomy cave, and not even the keen eye of an eagle would
 have spied him. He kept rubbing his eyes with his hands as he devised his subtle
 wiles, and he himself immediately maintained without a qualm: 'I have not seen
 a thing, I do not know a thing and I have not heard a word from anyone. I cannot
 give information nor can I win the reward.'" Thus Phoebus Apollo spoke and
 then sat down. (333–365) 280

And Hermes in answer told his side of the story, directing his words point-
 edly to Zeus, the ruler of all the gods. "Father Zeus, I shall indeed tell you the
 truth. For I am honest and I do not know how to lie. He came to our house today
 as the sun was just rising, in search of his shambling cattle. He brought none
 of the blessed gods as witnesses or observers and with great violence ordered
 me to confess; he made many threats of hurling me down into wide Tartarus,
 since he is in the full bloom of his glorious prime, while I was born only yesterday
 (as he too well knows himself) and do not look at all like a cattle rustler or a man
 of brawn. Believe me (for you claim to be my own dear father too) that I did not
 drive his cows home nor even cross the threshold—so may I prosper, what I tell 290
 you is the truth. I deeply revere Helios and the other gods; I love you and I am in
 dread of this fellow here. You know yourself that I am not guilty—I shall swear a
 great oath besides—no, by these beautifully ornate portals of the gods. Some-
 how, someday, I will pay him back, even though he is mighty, for his ruthless be-
 havior. Be on the side of a defenseless baby." Thus the Cyllenian slayer of Argus
 spoke, blinking in innocence, and he held his baby blanket on his shoulder and
 would not let it go. (366–388)

Zeus gave a great laugh as he saw the devious child knowingly and cleverly
 make his denials about the cattle. He ordered the two of them to act in accord
 and make a search; Hermes, in his role of guide, was to lead without any mali- 300
 cious intent and point out the spot where he had hidden away the mighty herd
 of cattle. The son of Cronus nodded his head and splendid Hermes obeyed, for
 the will of aegis-bearing Zeus easily persuaded him. (389–396)

THE RECONCILIATION BETWEEN HERMES AND APOLLO

The two very beautiful sons of Zeus hastened together to sandy Pylos, crossed
 the river Alpheus, and came to the lofty cave where the animals were sheltered
 in the nighttime. Then, while Hermes went into the rocky cavern and drove the



mighty head of cattle out into the light, the son of Leto looked away and noticed the cowhides on the steep rock and immediately asked glorious Hermes: “O sly rogue, how were you, a newborn infant, able to skin two cows? I do indeed wonder at the strength that will be yours in the future; there is no need to wait for you to grow up, O Cyllenian, son of Maia.” (397–408) 310

Thus he spoke and fashioned with his hands strong bonds out of willow.⁷ But they grew up in that very spot on the ground under their feet; and twisting and twining together, they readily covered over all the cattle of the field at the will of the trickster Hermes, while Apollo watched in wonder. Then the mighty slayer of Argus looked away to the ground, fire flashing from his eyes, in his desire to get out of his predicament. But it was very easy for him, just as he wished, to soften the far-shooting son of Leto, even though he was strong; he took up the lyre in his left hand and tried it by striking successive notes. The instrument resounded in startling fashion, and Phoebus Apollo laughed with delight as the lovely strains of the heavenly music pierced his being, and sweet yearning took hold of his heart while he listened. (409–423) 320

The son of Maia, growing bold as he played so beautifully, took his stand on the left side of Phoebus Apollo and began to sing a song—and lovely was the ensuing sound of his voice—fashioned on the theme of the immortal gods and the dark earth and how in the beginning they came into being and how each was allotted his due. Of the gods he honored first of all Mnemosyne, mother of the Muses, for she honored him, the son of Maia, as one of her own. The splendid son of Zeus paid tribute to each of the other immortal gods according to age and birth, mentioning all in the proper order, as he played the lyre on his arm. (423–433) 330

But an irresistible desire took hold of Apollo, heart and soul, and he spoke up, interrupting with winged words: “Cattle slayer, contriver, busy worker, good companion at a feast, this skill of yours is worth fifty cows—I think that we soon will be peacefully reconciled. Come now, tell me, ingenious son of Maia, was this wonderful achievement yours from birth, or did one of the gods or mortal humans give you this noble gift and teach you inspired song? For this newly uttered sound I hear is wonderful, and I tell you that no one, either mortal or god who dwells on Olympus, has ever before known it, except you, you trickster, son of Zeus and Maia. What skill! What Muse’s art! What salve for sorrow and despair! It gives the choice of three blessings together all at once: joy and love and sweet sleep. I follow the Olympian Muses who delight in dancing, the swelling beat of music, and the lovely tune of flutes, yet never have I been as thrilled at young men’s feasts by such clever delights as these. I marvel, O son of Zeus, at your charming playing. Since you know such a glorious skill, even though you are little, sit down, my boy, and listen to what I intend. For you yourself and your mother will have renown among the immortal gods. And I shall vow this to you truly: By this spear of cornel wood, I shall make you a renowned and prosperous guide among the immortal gods, and I shall give you splendid gifts and to the end I shall not deceive you.” (434–462) 340

Hermes answered him with clever words: “Archer-god, your questions are well considered; I do not begrudge your taking up my art. You will know it this very day. I want us to be friends, alike in what we think and what we say. You know all things in your heart, for you, son of Zeus, sit in the first place among the immortals, brave and strong. Zeus in his wisdom loves you as he rightly should and has granted you splendid gifts. And they say that you have acquired from 350



Hermes. Attic red-figure cup by the Euaion painter, ca. 460 B.C. Hermes stands with his attributes of petasus, caduceus, and winged boots. He wears the traveler's cloak and is bearded. Compare Giambologna's bronze, page 291. (Louvre, Paris, France)

the mouth of Zeus honors and, O archer-god, from him too every kind of divine oracular power. I know then that you are very rich in these gifts and you have only to make the choice of whatever you desire to learn. So, since your heart is set on playing the lyre, sing and play and be merry; accept this gift from me; and you, my dear friend, bestow glory upon me. With this clear-voiced companion in your hands,⁸ sing beautifully and well, knowing the art of proper presentation. Then with confidence take it to a luxurious feast and lovely dance and splendid revel, a thing of joy both night and day. Whoever makes demands of it after acquiring skill and knowledge is informed with sounds of every sort to delight the mind, for it is played by gentle familiarity and refuses to respond to toilsome drudgery. And whoever through lack of skill is from the first vehement in his demands is answered in return with wild and empty notes that clang upon the air. But you have only to make the choice of learning whatever you desire. To you I give this gift, splendid son of Zeus, and we both shall feed the cattle of the field on the pastures in the mountain and the plain where horses also graze. Even you, shrewd bargainer that you are, ought not to be violently angry." (463–495)

With these words he held out the lyre, and Phoebus Apollo accepted it. And he entrusted to Hermes the shining whip that he had and put him in charge of cattle herds. The son of Maia accepted this with joy. The far-shooting lord Apollo, the glorious son of Leto, took the lyre in his left hand and tried it by striking successive notes. It sounded in startling fashion at his touch, and the god sang a beautiful song in accompaniment. (496–502)

Afterward the two of them turned the cows out into the sacred meadow, and they, the very beautiful sons of Zeus, hastened back to snow-capped Olympus, all the while taking delight in the lyre. Zeus in his wisdom was pleased and united them both in friendship; Hermes has loved the son of Leto steadfastly, and he still does even now, as is evident from the pledges made when Hermes entrusted his lovely lyre to the archer-god and Apollo took it on his arm and learned how to play. But Hermes himself fashioned another instrument and learned another art, producing the sound of pipes that are heard from afar.⁹ (503–512)

Then the son of Leto said to Hermes, "I fear, cunning guide, that you may steal my lyre and my curved bow; for you have from Zeus the prerogative of establishing the business of barter among people on the nourishing earth. Yet if, for my sake, you would deign to swear the great oath of the gods, either by a nod of your head or by the mighty waters of the river Styx, you would do everything that would satisfy my heart's desire." Then the son of Maia nodded and promised that he would never steal a thing from all that the far-shooter possessed and that he would never come near his mighty house. In turn Apollo, the son of Leto, nodded in loving friendship that no one else among mortals

would be more dear, neither god nor mortal sprung from Zeus, and said, "I shall pledge that this bond between us will be trusted and honored both in my heart and that of all the gods. Besides, I will give you in addition a very beautiful golden staff of prosperity and wealth, three-branched and protective; it will keep you safe while, in the name of all the gods, you accomplish by word and by deed the good things which I declare that I learn from the divine voice of Zeus. (513–532)

"As for this gift of prophecy which you mention, O best of Zeus' sons, it is not allowed by god that you or any other of the immortals learn what the mind of Zeus knows; but I have pledged, vowed, and sworn a mighty oath that no other one of the eternal gods (apart from me) should know the infinite wisdom